

The Call to Adventure

Joseph Campbell was born in New York City on March 26, 1904, the son of Charles and Josephine Campbell. His passion for mythology began when he was a young boy and his father took him and his younger brother, Charlie, to Buffalo Bill's Wild West Show at Madison Square Garden, and to the Museum of Natural History, where he became fascinated with Indian totem poles. By the time he was twelve he was voraciously reading books about American Indians. He soon recognized the parallels between these stories and those of his own Roman Catholic tradition, a discovery that would fire a cross-cultural study in the arcane discipline of mythology for the rest of his life.

As a student at prep school in New Milford, Connecticut, his favorite studies were biology and math. He went on to attend Dartmouth in 1921 for one year, but felt a "complete disorientation" there and even considered dropping out of college to enter business.

In the summer of 1922 a family friend gave him a biography of Leonardo da Vinci that so inspired him he transferred to Columbia University to "shift my interest from science to cultural history" and the humanities.

Campbell poses with a young Yakima woman at the Yakima Rodeo in Yakima, Washington, 1925.

216

STUART BROWN: Can you tell us about your grandparents and your Irish background?

JOSEPH CAMPBELL: I didn't really know my grandparents well. My father's father came over at the end of the potato famine in Ireland. He was a peasant and he became a gardener on an estate in Waltham, Massachusetts. My father grew up there. And his mother, also, was from Ireland. As a boy Dad got a job in a department store and became one of their major salesmen, and then they sent him to New York to open the New York office. So I was born in New York.

I remember when I was a little boy visiting my grandfather. He had a great white beard as a grandfather ought to. That's about all I remember. That was a long, long, long way back. And my mother's father I met only once. Mother was a New York girl but



Joseph Campbell, age thirteen weeks, with his parents, Charles W. and Josephine Campbell, 1904.

her mother was from Scotland and was a pretty, lovely, wonderful woman, and she took very good care of us. My mother had a beautiful brother who was a glorious swimmer. He died of diabetes when he was around twenty-two. I can remember swimming with him when I was a kid; he was the only other person in the family that played a role at all in the building of my ideals and idealism.

I never thought very much about being thoroughly Celtic-Irish until well on in my college years, when I began to get a real sense of what the Celtic consciousness was and what a good fortune it was to come out of that realm of wonderful, rich verbal fantasy. The whole fairyland world of Europe is out of Ireland, really.

And then in my graduate years I became interested in the Arthurian material, which is thoroughly Celtic, and gradually I got a sense of my relationship to their mentality.

BROWN: What were your boyhood years like? Were you an avid student?

CAMPBELL: From very early—around four or five years old—I was fascinated by American Indians, and that became my real studying. I went to school and had no problems with my studies, but my own enthusiasm was in this maverick realm of the American Indian mythologies. We lived in New Rochelle [New York] in those years, right next door to the public library. When I



Campbell (right) at around age four with his younger brother Charlie, about 1908. In later years Campbell reveled in the family lore. He and his brother were once strolling with their grandmother and baby sister down Riverside Drive in New York City when a woman stopped them. "You seem like two nice little boys," the woman said. Joe boldly responded, "I have Indian blood in me." Then his brother piped in, "And I have dog blood."

was about eleven I had read all the books about Indians in the children's library and was actually admitted to the stacks. I remember coming home from the library with stacks of books. And I think that's where my life as a scholar began. I *know* it did.

There they all were: all the reports of the Bureau of Ethnology, [Frank H.] Cushing and [Franz] Boas, and the lot of them. By the time I was thirteen I knew about as much about the American Indian as a good many anthropologists that I have met since. They know the sociological interpretations of why the Indians are the way they are or were, but they don't know much about Indians. And I did know.



BROWN: Did you have any heroes in your youth? Any lionized characters who became an early mentor for you?

CAMPBELL: Well, my parents found a lovely place in the Pocono Mountains of Pennsylvania along about 1917, and right nearby was a man whose books about Indians I had been reading. And so he became my first guru, or teacher. His name was Elmer Gregor and he wrote books about American Indians. He had been out in the Indian country. In those days—this is 1912, '13, '14, '15—the Indian wars were still going on, and “the only good Indian



The Campbell family bungalow in Pike County, Pennsylvania, about 1917.

was a dead Indian” and all of that. So there were Indians in the wind, even though we were in the East.

And so this beautiful place became my real discovery of nature. My emphasis on biology and nature and the body in my writing about myth comes out of those years. It is really a combination that comes from this man, who was a naturalist as well as an Indian scholar. He put me right on the road. Elmer Gregor. I remember him as a great. We used to communicate across the dining room with Indian sign language, and all that kind of thing.



Buffalo Bill's Wild West Show (above), about 1910. This photo was taken by Campbell's father on one of the family excursions to see Buffalo Bill Cody and his spectacular troupe of cavalymen, sharpshooters, and Indian warriors. The show ignited the young Campbell's lifelong fascination with American Indians.

Buffalo Bill Cody (right), frontier scout, hero of dime novels, and a major force in the mythologizing of the American West, enjoys a cigar and newspaper in his tent after a performance. (Courtesy of the Buffalo Bill Historical Society, Cody, Wyoming.)



My career as a mythologist began almost immediately with Buffalo Bill's Wild West Show at Madison Square Garden [1910]. He came for two or three years, then he died and the group that replaced him was called the 101 Ranch. One of the Indians in the sideshow was Irontail, whose head had just appeared on the Indian-head nickel. He'd sit in profile to the people who filed by as they took their nickels out of their pockets, looked, bowed their heads, and went on.

Joseph Campbell,
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